

Session 3: Christ and the Spirit

Key Takeaways

- For Paul, apostleship includes his calling to the Gentiles (all non-Jews) with the message of Christ crucified.
- Apostleship includes suffering.
- Paul refers to the Gospel as the “mystery of God.”
- The Gospel of Jesus is a revelation that comes only from the Spirit and not from the world, and the Spirit within is not a spirit from the world but God himself.
- The Spirit is associated with wisdom and power, as is Jesus Christ.
- The Greek words *psychikos* (ψυχικός) and *pneumatikos* (πνευματικός) are two terms Paul uses to contrast attitude and behavior. A *psychikos* is something unspiritual or natural—the natural person—and *pneumatikos* is literally “spiritually”—that which can only be spiritually discerned.

Summary Verses

Within the first two chapters, Paul lays out a summary of the entire letter.

1 Corinthians 1:1 NIV

Paul, called to be an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God ...

1 Corinthians 1:23a NIV

We preach Christ crucified ...

1 Corinthians 1:24b NIV

Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God.

1 Corinthians 2:7 NIV

No, we declare God’s wisdom, a mystery that has been hidden and that God destined for our glory before time began.

1 Corinthians 2:12 NIV

What we have received is not the spirit of the world, but the Spirit who is from God, so that we may understand what God has freely given us.

Paul the Apostle

What does apostleship mean to Paul?

1. A statement of authority
2. A servant/slave of Jesus Christ
3. Not based on natural gifting but chosen and called by God according to his will
4. A steward of the mystery of God
5. Sacrifice and suffering

In 1 Corinthians 4:1, he talks about himself, the other apostles, and Apollos as servants (not slaves here) and as “stewards” of the mystery of God (Greek: *oikonomos/οἰκονόμος*—the manager of a household).

More specifically, for Paul this meant being called to the Gentiles and the non-Jews with this message. It also meant to suffer.

Acts 9:15-16 NIV

¹⁵ But the Lord said to Ananias, “Go! This man is my chosen instrument to proclaim my name to the Gentiles and their kings and to the people of Israel. ¹⁶ I will show him how much he must suffer for my name.”

Philippians 3:8 NIV

What is more, I consider everything a loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whose sake I have lost all things. I consider them garbage, that I may gain Christ.

We Preach Christ Crucified

What is the significance of Paul saying here that “We preach Christ crucified”? Paul could have said Christ risen and exalted or Christ the healer and Lord of the universe. Why is it a stumbling block to Jews and foolishness to pagans?

“Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God” (1 Cor. 1:24b)

In what way does Paul see the crucified Messiah as wiser than human wisdom and stronger than human strength?

1 Corinthians 2:7 NIV

No, we declare God’s wisdom, a mystery that has been hidden and that God destined for our glory before time began.

The Mystery of God

Mystery here means something that is being revealed and that comes to us by revelation. This phrase also occurs in 1 Corinthians 2:7, 4:1, 13:2, 14:2, 15:51 (also see Eph. 1:9; 3:3; 3:9; 5:32; 6:19 and Col. 1:26-27; 2:2; 4:3).

What does it mean for God’s wisdom through the cross of Christ to have been hidden “before time began”? How is this linked to God’s destiny for human beings as “our glory”?

These things are revealed to us by the Spirit.

Glory and the Work of the Spirit

1 Corinthians 2:10b-12 NIV

¹⁰ The Spirit searches all things, even the deep things of God. ¹¹ For who knows a person's thoughts except their own spirit within them? In the same way no one knows the thoughts of God except the Spirit of God.

¹² **What we have received is not the spirit of the world, but the Spirit who is from God, so that we may understand what God has freely given us.**

Pay attention to how Paul frames the role of the Spirit in this passage.

- Revelation only comes by the Spirit and not from the world, and the Spirit within is not a spirit from the world but is God himself
- Not the spirit of the world (Greek: τὸ πνεῦμα τοῦ κόσμου)
- The Spirit who is from God, and the Spirit of God (Greek: τὸ πνεῦμα τὸ ἐκ τοῦ θεοῦ)
- The Spirit is associated both with wisdom and with power, as is Jesus Christ
- Received freely (also see [1 Cor. 4:7](#))
- Paul cites [Isaiah 64:4](#) in [verse 9](#) and [Isaiah 40:13](#) in [verse 16](#)

In [1 Corinthians 2:14](#), ψυχικός (Greek: *psychikos*) and πνευματικός (Greek: *pneumatikos*) are two terms by which Paul contrasts attitudes and behavior.

- *Psychikos* is “unspiritual” or “natural” (the natural person)
- *Pneumatikos* is literally “spiritually” (spiritually discerned)

This takes us back to [1 Corinthians 1:26-31](#) where Paul sets up a contrast between the foolish and the wise of the world.

Reflection Question

In the [first chapter of 1 Corinthians](#), Paul refers to himself as an apostle. According to Paul, what does it mean to be an apostle?